

Notes on the Valley Survey

The survey team left the station at dawn on the second of May. The river bent twice before it reached the quiet market town. Every window on the narrow street held a small clay pot of herbs. A baker named Ilse opened her shutters an hour before the sun. Children chased paper boats along the gutter after the rain.

The clock above the post office ran four minutes slow all winter. Nobody could remember who had planted the row of tall poplars. On market days the square smelled of apples, rope and wet wool. A lone pelican watched the surveyors from a flat rock. An old cartographer kept his maps rolled in a copper tube. He claimed that every road eventually returned to its own beginning. The schoolteacher wrote the date on the board in careful round letters. Pigeons gathered on the roof of the granary to watch the carts arrive.

A violin could be heard most evenings from the house with green doors. The ferry crossed the lake six times a day, weather permitting. Its captain wore the same grey coat in summer and in snow. Travellers often asked for directions to a bridge that no longer existed. The innkeeper answered patiently and drew them a new route on a napkin. In autumn the hills turned the colour of rust and honey. Lanterns were hung along the harbour wall for the evening festival.

A small brass band rehearsed in the barn behind the chapel. The librarian stamped each returned book with a satisfied nod. Snow arrived late that year and stayed until the middle of spring. The miller repaired his wheel with timber from a broken oak. Most letters to the town arrived on Tuesdays, carried by a tired mule. Someone painted a blue door at the end of the lane and left no name.

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The Valley Survey, Continued

By the third week the team had mapped every path along the ridge. An old cartographer kept his maps rolled in a copper tube. He claimed that every road eventually returned to its own beginning. The schoolteacher wrote the date on the board in careful round letters. Pigeons gathered on the roof of the granary to watch the carts arrive.

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The final report recommended a footbridge near the old ford. An old cartographer kept his maps rolled in a copper tube. He claimed that every road eventually returned to its own beginning. The schoolteacher wrote the date on the board in careful round letters. Pigeons gathered on the roof of the granary to watch the carts arrive.

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